Being an obliging sort of person, you drive down to the local hardware store and take a look at the range of power drills on display. But without a bit more background, you'd be hard put to make me happy. If I'm trying to assemble a large bed with a lot of screws, a small and inexpensive cordless electric drill, or maybe even a cordless screwdriver, should suffice, and a heavier model would just be cumbersome. On the other hand, if I'm going to install some new shelves on a brick wall in my garage, I'll need a more powerful hammer drill as well as a set of masonry drill bits and some screw anchors. If the garage has no power outlets, the drill will have to be of the more expensive cordless variety.

To get things done effectively, you need a clear understanding both of what you're trying to achieve and of the ultimate goal or purpose of your work. Studies have demonstrated that team collaboration improves significantly when members share a clearly identifiable goal.[4] This is equally true for software development. If you are to deliver effective solutions for the problems your clients face, you need to understand the underlying business goals.

> **EXERCISE 3.1** In the previous chapter, you worked on a timetable application to publish timetables and real-time data feeds for train lines. That client also subsidizes bus companies for the bus trips they run. Currently, the bus companies send in paper forms detailing the bus trips they do each month, and they're paid on this basis. Management now wants you to write an application that keeps track of the real-time bus data and matches it against the subsidy requests that the bus companies send in. Try to articulate the business goals for this project in a few short sentences.

3.3.1 The vision statement

One useful way to express what a project is supposed to achieve is to write up a *vision statement*. A vision statement outlines the expected outcomes and objectives of the project in a few concise and compelling phrases. It gives the team an understanding of what they're trying to achieve, helping to motivate them and focus their efforts on the essential value proposition of the product. It provides a beacon for all to see, helping teams align their direction and concentrate their efforts on building features that actively contribute to the project's goals.

> **TIP** The vision statement should be simple, clear, and concise—short enough to read and assimilate in a few minutes. It should also be intimately familiar to the whole team. Indeed, in the midst of an iteration, when requirements are changing quickly and frequently, it's all too easy for teams to get sidetracked by minor details, and the vision statement can remind them about the broader goals of the project.

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[4] Panagiotis Mitkidis et al., "Collective-Goal Ascription Increases Cooperation in Humans," PLOS ONE (May 2013) 8:5, http://www.plosone.org/article/info%3Adoi%2F10.1371%2Fjournal.pone.0064776.